National
Qualifications
2023

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ESOL
Listening Transcript

WEDNESDAY, 24 MAY

9:00 AM – 9:45 AM (approx)

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Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 1

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

Where special arrangements have been agreed in advance to allow the reading of the material, it should be read by one male and two female or one female and two male speakers. Sections marked **(t)** should be read by the teacher.

(t) Recording 1

Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice.

You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 1 before the recording begins.

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

Sharma Hello, and welcome to the afternoon show. Now, we've got plenty to talk about this week, but we're going to start with electric cars. My guests today are Jason Cooper, motoring correspondent, and Alice Pearson, senior lecturer in environmental studies. Good morning to you both.

Jason Morning.

Alice Good morning.

Sharma So, Jason, let me start with you. How are sales of electric cars doing?

Jason Well, despite an economic downturn, sales of electric and hybrid cars hit record levels in March, showing a strong demand for greener vehicles.

Sharma What do the numbers look like?

Jason If you take both electric and plug-in hybrids — that's a car that can switch from electric to petrol — you're looking at 13.9% of the market. That's up from 7.3% a year earlier. Buyers picked up 22,000 electric cars and 17,000 plug-in hybrids. Car number plates change in March, meaning that buyers hold off until then in order to keep a higher resale value.

Sharma So, Alice, good news all round?

Alice Hmm — maybe not all round but certainly the figures are encouraging. There are still a couple of problems we need to overcome.

Sharma And what are these?

Alice One of them is the environmental cost of mining the metals for the batteries — these include nickel, copper, cobalt and chromium. Take just nickel, which is mainly mined in Australia, Canada, Indonesia, Russia and the Philippines. This can lead to sulphur dioxide filling the skies, dug-up earth covered in toxic dust and rivers running blood-red. However, I can say that progress is being made here and the industry is beginning to clean up its act. Though the disposal of the heavy batteries when they reach the end of their useful life is also a challenge.

Jason Alice, I'd say we're moving forward here too. As time goes on, as batteries get better, they're also getting smaller and more eco-friendly.

Sharma Yes, but there's still the problem of being able to charge up on longer journeys. Jason, where are we with that?

Jason Let's think back to the early days of petrol engines. When people began to buy cars, there were very few places to buy petrol. In fact, there were no specialist filling stations at first. If you needed to buy fuel, you would go to a shop, and they would sell you some. If motorists wanted to go on longer journeys between towns, they would carry a spare can of fuel in the car and stop to fill up their tanks. As time went on and more and more people bought cars the infrastructure improved and petrol became more available, though the first specialist petrol station wasn't established in Britain until 1919 — after the First World War. With electric cars, we have the same process going on with charging today.

Alice The thing is, many people don't want to use a car for longer journeys. They just want something to get them to work, or to potter around town, shopping, visiting friends and so on.

Jason Or if you do want to make longer journeys sometimes, you can buy a hybrid and have the best of both worlds.

Alice Or you can run a small electric and maybe if you want something from time to time with a longer range, you can hire a petrol one.

Jason True, but my feeling is that as batteries improve and charge points increase and charging becomes quicker, the number of people buying hybrids will drop.

Alice So, we're looking at the death of the internal combustion engine?

Jason Well, the steam engine had its time. The petrol engine will too — and so will electric cars at some point. We haven't even begun to talk about the possibilities of hydrogen as a fuel.

(10 second pause after first reading)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

TONE

[Turn over

Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 2

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

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(t) Recording 2

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You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 2 before the recording begins.

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

John Hi Sally, thank you so much for agreeing to meet with me today.

Sally Of course, John. It's great to see you and I'm more than happy to help. So, you mentioned that you're considering changing career. How exciting!

John Well, exciting is one word for it. Not sure it's the one I'd go for though! More like terrifying, though I'm certain I've done the right thing. I've had this nagging feeling recently that I've been going down the wrong route and I just want a fresh start. I know you did something similar recently, so I thought you'd be well placed to give me some advice to make me feel a bit more self-assured.

Sally I did, yes. I'd been working in finance for almost 15 years but, a couple of years ago I jumped ship and followed my dream to become a zookeeper! Honestly, the move was long overdue, and I really expected a bumpier ride, but everyone was surprisingly accommodating — even my old boss. I totally get where you're coming from, though; taking the leap can seem extremely unnerving, particularly if you've never worked in an industry before.

John So, where did you start?

Sally The first thing I found that I needed to do was to tackle any feelings of doubt or failure. While I'd undoubtedly fallen out of love with the role, I'd spent the majority of my working life successfully progressing up a ladder within my previous organisation to a really decent level, and it felt like I was back at square one. That was probably the toughest part. However, what I came to realise was that, even though I'd come from a completely different background from many other applicants, the skills and experience I had gained were no less credible.

John That's really reassuring to hear. But I think the difference between us is that you had a clear plan of what you wanted to do. I just know that I want to make a change, but I've no idea what.

Sally I reckon you do know, you just need to get your thoughts straight. My advice would be to start with a simple spider diagram on a blank sheet of paper where you just jot down as many skills or passions as you can in two minutes. You can then start to broaden the diagram out with specific examples of times you've used these skills, giving yourself a handy visual map of areas, you know you can excel in. You don't need to restrict your diagram to salaried work either. It's just as valid to include any knowledge or expertise you've picked up through volunteering.

John That's a good idea. I've also tossed around the idea of doing a course or something but it's hard to know what to sign up for until I've figured out what I want to do. I expect I could always see if I can lend a hand at some local charities or places like that to test the water ahead of tying myself into anything concrete.

Sally I think that's a great idea. It'll also help you to make your CV look more appealing to prospective employers. One thing that I found when I was applying for new positions was that I needed to be more creative because I didn't have specific experience in that field. Being a bit out of practice, I searched online and found loads of examples to help me establish what's expected from a CV nowadays. I used a template to design my CV slightly differently and put a key skills section at the top. My husband isn't much use at all this as he's been self-employed for years, so, instead of asking him to check it over, I reached out to a recruitment specialist for a second opinion. The best tip she gave me was to remember that my old career isn't anything to be ashamed of; in fact, it's an asset that could give me an edge over other applicants.

John Thanks so much again, Sally. You've given me lots to think about. Let me get the coffee as a thank you.

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

TONE

[Turn over

Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 3

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

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(t) Recording 3

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You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 3 before the recording begins.

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

Lecturer Hi, good morning — actually, it is quite a good morning, weather-wise. Those of you from overseas can take note that it doesn't rain every day in Scotland. Fine, so today I'd like to have a look at Gaelic-medium education within the Scottish education system. But first, a bit of background.

So, if you go back a thousand years, Gaelic was spoken across the whole of Scotland except for two fairly small areas: the southeast — Lothian and Borders, where Old English was the main language, and in the far northeast — Caithness, Orkney, and Shetland, which had been colonised by the Vikings and spoke their language, Old Norse.

Since then, Gaelic has been in steady decline, right up to today, where there are about 55,000 speakers left — that's about one percent of the population. Gaelic lives beside the most widespread and aggressive language in the world — English. Also, in the 18th century, a number of rebellions in the Highlands against the British government led to Gaelic being actively suppressed by law. These drastic measures eased somewhat as time went by, but children were discouraged from speaking Gaelic at school, even in the playground. And their parents generally agreed. In the 19th century and well into the 20th century, they saw English as the language of progress and employment. We can't really blame them for this. Job prospects in the Highlands were poor, even for those with an education, so many Gaelic speakers moved away from the region: the British Empire offered multiple opportunities, providing they could speak English.

And that's how things continued, until comparatively recently. Let me give you some figures. In 1985 the number of children in Gaelic-medium education was 24, and it only existed in the West Highlands, not in the cities. Today, well, according to the most recent figures, there are over 4000, and demand is still growing. Glasgow has its Gaelic secondary school, which is fed by three primaries. In Edinburgh there is a Gaelic primary school and plans to move the Gaelic department in a secondary school to set up a dedicated Gaelic school. Now, that's Edinburgh, which as you know is on the east coast and quite far away from the Highlands. So, let's think about this for a moment. In the 19th and early 20th centuries, Highland immigration into Glasgow was fairly

massive, so it's understandable there are many families there whose ancestors spoke Gaelic. But not so many Highlanders made the longer journey to Edinburgh which of course was less industrial. Something's going on here, something that seems to indicate a positive future for Gaelic in Scottish schools.

So, what are the reasons for parents opting for a Gaelic-medium education, which, by the way, is offered in just under half of local council areas? Well, for some, it's a heritage thing, and you might say the core group are those where the parents speak the language and Gaelic is the medium of the home. These are actually comparatively few. Then there are those whose grandparents or great-grandparents spoke Gaelic but, due to discouragement, their parents don't, and they would like to connect the children with their family history. There's then a wider group who have Highland ancestry, but perhaps coming from the eastern or southern Highlands, can't lay claim to Gaelic-speaking ancestors for a century or so back. That may be so — they might have lived in, say, Glasgow, for generations — but they still feel an attachment to the language. And there's another group with purely Lowland ancestry, who have no family connection with Gaelic whatsoever, but who feel it's important because it was once the main language of Scotland.

So, those are what we might call heritage groups, of different levels of ancestral connection to Gaelic. However, there's yet another group, which even includes recent immigrants to Scotland, whose motivation is simply that they believe in bilingual education and Gaelic provides the only chance for this in the Scottish state system. And this is the main group that I'd like to consider today.

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

(t) You now have one minute to check your answers.

(*1 minute pause*)

(t) This is the end of the listening test.

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